



Fort William, shown here in the 1700s, was built after the English East India Company moved its main Bengal trading station to Calcutta in 1690.

THE ENGLISH EAST INDIA

COMPANY had been a presence in Bengal since the early 17th century. Seeking greater security for their trade, a new base, **Fort William**, named after William III, was established in 1690 in what is now Calcutta. The fort, continually enlarged and improved, would be critical to the later British dominance in India.

In 1690, English philosopher **John Locke** (1632–1704) wrote *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding*. It marked Locke as a **key thinker** in the Western philosophical tradition, above all for his assertion that knowledge of the world came through experience of it, and that the basis of this understanding was reasoned, empirical (based on observation) thought. Reinforcing many of his established ideas about property rights, religious

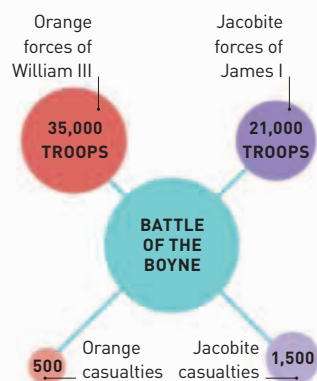


Philosopher John Locke
John Locke contended that there is a contract between monarch and people under which the monarch can be overthrown if he abuses it.

toleration, and monarchy, it also ensured his influence in debates about **liberty and reason** in 18th-century France and America.

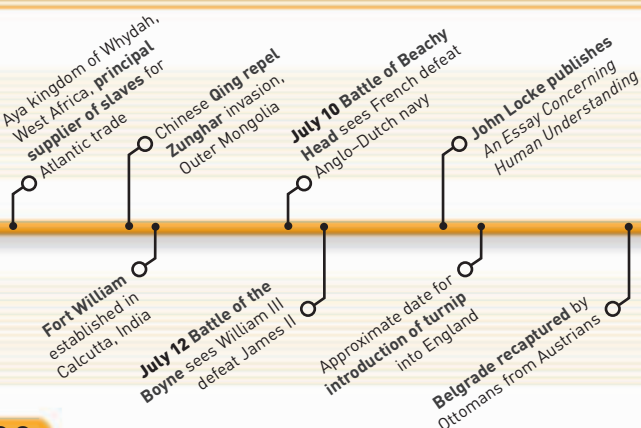
The **turnip**, a basic root crop of the agricultural revolution of the 17th century, was **first cultivated in England in about 1690**. The Dutch, to make best use of their limited lands, had already discovered that **crop rotation** (arable crops alternated with root crops rather than leaving fields fallow) not only improved fertility but provided food for sheep whose manure furthered productivity.

On July 12, 1690, William III's victory over the deposed Catholic James II at the **Battle of the Boyne**, in Ireland, was decisive in maintaining the **Protestant supremacy** that had been established there by the Glorious Revolution of 1688. In Ireland, brutal **sectarian violence** would continue for centuries.



Battle of the Boyne, Ireland

The Orange army of William III inflicted a decisive defeat on the Jacobites of James II, giving the lie to William's "bloodless revolution."



This woodcut, taken from the title page of a pamphlet, shows the devastation of Port Royal, Jamaica, by both an earthquake and a tsunami in June 1692.

“THE EUROPEANS ARE VERY QUIET; THEY DO NOT EXCITE ANY DISTURBANCES... THEY DO NO HARM TO ANYONE, THEY COMMIT NO CRIMES...”

Kangxi, Chinese Qing emperor, announces the Edict of Toleration, 1692

ALTHOUGH THE NINE YEARS' WAR had quickly settled in 1688 into a stalemate on land that would last to 1697, at sea the Grand Alliance enjoyed a clear superiority over France. The six-day **Battle of La Hogue** from May to June 1692 saw much of the French fleet either beached or destroyed by fireships. It **ended hopes of a French invasion of England**.

At 11:43am on June 7, 1692, a catastrophic **earthquake struck Port Royal**, capital of the English colony of Jamaica, and one of the most important ports in the Caribbean, as well as a legendary base for pirates. **Most of the city sank beneath the sea**. With the subsequent tsunami and outbreaks of disease, the death toll was about 5,000.

In **Salem**, Massachusetts, in late 1691, young girls started having fits and hallucinations, citing demonic possession. This led to claims of witchcraft, which by 1692 had reached the point of

hysteria. On June 10, an elderly widow, Bridget Bishop, was **hanged as a witch**, and by September a further 18 people had been executed on the same charge, and one man crushed to death. Trials for witchcraft were no longer common in England by this time, and the **mass hysteria** of Salem remains hard to explain.

Jesuit missionaries had been in East Asia since the 16th century. In contrast to Japan (see 1597–99), in China they were **valued by a succession of emperors**, not least for their knowledge of western science. They made many converts, and in 1692 the Kangxi Emperor issued an **edict of toleration of Christianity**.



Salem Witch Trial

The trial of George Jacobs was one of many in a Puritan community riven by petty jealousies, where none disputed the existence of Satan.

